

Word family: **outside / outsider / outsiders**

Base word: outside

Related forms: outsider

Part of speech: preposition(介詞) / adverb(副詞) / adjective(形容詞) / noun(名詞)

Your sentence:

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the **outside world**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **outside world** means **everything beyond the person’s immediate private experience—especially the surrounding environment, people, traffic, conversations, and other external sounds**.

Meaning: The world or environment beyond oneself or beyond the protected/private space one is currently in.

繁體中文: **自己當下的私人空間或內在體驗以外的外部環境, 包括周圍的人、聲音、活動和現實世界**

中文翻譯:

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the outside world.”

「那感覺就像有人替**周圍的外部世界**按下了靜音鍵一樣。」

In this context:

the outside world = 耳機使用者自身以外、周圍充滿聲音和活動的現實環境

1. **outside + place/container/building(地方／容器／建築物) — 在……外面; 位於……範圍之外**

Here, **outside** is a preposition.

Meaning: Not inside a particular place, building, area, or boundary.

Practice 1

> “She waited **outside** the station.”

「她在車站**外面**等候。」

Practice 2

> “There is a café **outside** the building.”

「大樓**外面**有一間咖啡店。」

outside + place = 位於某個有明確界線的地方之外，而不是其內部

2. **outside** = outdoors / not inside a building (戶外) — 在外面; 到戶外

Here, **outside** is an adverb.

Practice 3

> “It’s warm enough to eat **outside**.”

「天氣夠暖，可以在**戶外／外面**吃飯。」

Practice 4

> “The children are playing **outside**.”

「孩子們正在**外面／戶外**玩耍。」

outside = 在建築物或室內空間之外的戶外地方

Compare:

> “Wait **outside** the office.”

> **outside** = preposition

> “Wait **outside**.”

> **outside** = adverb

3. **outside** = outer/external part (物件／建築物的外部) — 外面的; 外部的

Here, **outside** is an adjective.

Meaning: Located on or relating to the outer part rather than the inside.

Practice 5

> “The **outside** wall needs to be repaired.”

「大樓的**外牆**需要維修。」

Practice 6

> “Clean both the inside and **outside** surfaces.”

「把內部和**外部表面**都清潔乾淨。」

outside + noun = 位於物件、建築物或範圍外側的

4. **the outside = external surface/part (外部／外側) — 外面; 外部表面**

Here, **outside** is a noun.

Practice 7

> “The box is damaged on the **outside**.”

「盒子的**外部表面**有損壞。」

Practice 8

> “The building looks modern from the **outside**.”

「這座建築從**外面看**很現代化。」

the outside = 某物相對於內部而言的外層、外側或外部部分

5. **outside world (自身／封閉空間以外的現實環境) — 外界; 外部世界**

This is your original meaning.

Meaning: The environment, society, or reality beyond a person, private space, building, institution, or isolated situation.

Practice 9 — Original

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the **outside world**.”

「那感覺就像有人替**周圍的外界**按下了靜音鍵一樣。」

Practice 10

> “The thick walls blocked out most sounds from the **outside world**.”

「厚牆隔絕了來自**外界環境**的大部分聲音。」

Practice 11

> “For a few hours, she wanted to disconnect from the **outside world**.”

「她想暫時幾個小時與**外界的人和事情**隔絕。」

outside world = 某人自身、私人空間或封閉環境以外的外界現實

6. **outside = beyond a limit/boundary/range (界限／範圍) — 超出……範圍; 不在……之內**

This is a major figurative extension of physical boundaries.

Meaning: Beyond the limits of a rule, category, range, responsibility, or area.

Practice 12

> “That question is **outside** the scope of this report.”

「那個問題**超出了這份報告的討論範圍**。」

Practice 13

> “The temperature is **outside** the normal range.”

「溫度**超出了正常範圍**。」

outside + limit/range/scope = 不屬於某個既定界限、範圍或類別之內

This same concept appears in:

* **outside my expertise** → 超出我的專業範圍

* **outside the rules** → 不在規則容許範圍內

* **outside working hours** → 正常工作時間以外

7. **outside = not belonging to an organization/group (機構／群體以外) — 外來的; 非內部的**

Meaning: Coming from or belonging to someone or something beyond a particular organization, group, or system.

Practice 14

> “The company brought in an **outside** consultant.”

「公司聘請了一名**來自公司以外的外部顧問**。」

Practice 15

> “They received help from an **outside** organization.”

「他們獲得了一個**外部機構**的協助。」

outside person/help/organization = 並非來自某機構或群體內部, 而是來自外部的

Common combinations:

* **outside consultant** = 外聘顧問

* **outside expert** = 外部專家

* **outside help** = 外來協助

* **outside influence** = 外部影響

8. **outside = not part of the main job/activity (主要工作／活動以外) — 額外的; 業餘的; 職務以外的**

Meaning: Not connected with someone's main job, organization, or principal activity.

Practice 16

> “Employees must declare any **outside** employment.”

「員工必須申報任何**本職工作以外的其他受僱工作**。」

Practice 17

> “Her **outside** interests include photography and hiking.”

「她在主要工作以外的**個人興趣**包括攝影和遠足。」

****outside activity/interest/employment = 不屬於某人主要職務或主要活動範圍內的****

This develops from the same concept of being ****beyond a defined boundary****.

9. ****outside = external source/cause/influence (外來來源／因素) — 外部的; 來自外界的****

****Meaning:**** Originating beyond the person, organization, system, or situation being discussed.

Practice 18

> “The decision was made without ****outside**** pressure.”

「這項決定是在沒有受到****外界壓力****的情況下作出的。」

Practice 19

> “The system is protected from ****outside**** interference.”

「系統受到保護，不會受到****外部干擾****。」

****outside influence/pressure/interference = 從某個系統、群體或個人以外而來的影響或干預****

10. ****outside chance/possibility (可能性很低) — 極小的可能性; 微乎其微的機會****

This is a useful established expression.

****Meaning:**** A small but still real possibility that something may happen.

Practice 20

> “There is an ****outside chance**** that the tickets will become available.”

「仍有****很小但並非完全沒有的可能性****會有門票重新放出。」

Practice 21

> “She has an ****outside chance**** of winning the competition.”

「她仍有**一線但相當渺茫的機會**贏得比賽。」

****outside chance = 成功可能性很低, 但並非完全不可能的機會****

This is a genuinely specialized development of ****outside**** and should not be translated literally as 「外面的機會」.

11. ****outside = maximum/extreme estimate (估算上限) — 最大可能的; 最寬鬆上限的****

This use is less common than the others but still current, particularly in ****outside estimate****.

****Meaning:**** The highest or most extreme reasonable estimate.

Practice 22

> “Two weeks would be an ****outside estimate**** for the repair.”

「兩星期應該已是這次維修時間的****最大合理估算上限****。」

Practice 23

> “At an ****outside estimate****, the project should cost no more than \$50,000.”

「按****最高合理估算****, 專案成本應不超過五萬元。」

****outside estimate = 在合理範圍內所作的最大／最極端估算****

This is somewhat more common in British English.

12. ****outsider = person not belonging to a group/community (群體以外的人) — 外人; 局外人****

This is the most important family extension.

****Meaning:**** Someone who does not belong to a particular group, organization, community, profession, or social circle.

Practice 24

> “As an ****outsider****, he found the company culture difficult to understand.”

「作為一個****不屬於公司內部群體的外來者****, 他覺得公司的文化很難理解。」

Practice 25

> “Local traditions can seem unusual to **outsiders**.”

「當地傳統對**不屬於該社群的外人**來說可能顯得很特別。」

outsider = 不屬於某個特定群體、圈子或社群的人

13. **outsider** = person/team not expected to succeed (不被看好的人／隊伍) — 冷門; 不被看好的參賽者

This is a genuinely different and important sense of **outsider**.

Meaning: A competitor considered unlikely to win or succeed.

Practice 26

> “The team entered the tournament as an **outsider**.”

「這支球隊參賽時屬於**不被看好、勝算較低的冷門隊伍**。」

Practice 27

> “She began the race as a rank **outsider** but finished second.”

「她賽前被視為**幾乎沒有人看好的冷門參賽者**，最後卻取得第二名。」

outsider = 在比賽或競爭中被認為成功機會較低、不屬於主要熱門的一方

Notice the connection with:

> **outside chance**

Both contain the idea of being **away from the expected/main group of likely winners**.

Important distinction: outside vs outdoors

outside

Can refer to:

- * physical location
- * external part
- * beyond a boundary
- * external people/influences

> “Wait outside.”

「在外面等。」

outdoors

Specifically means **in the open air**, not inside a building.

> “We spent the afternoon outdoors.”

「我們整個下午都在戶外活動。」

You cannot normally replace **outside** with **outdoors** in:

> “outside the normal range” ❌ *outdoors the normal range*

Important distinction: **outside vs external**

outside

Very common and broad.

> “outside help”

「外來協助」

external

More formal/technical and means originating from or situated beyond something.

> “external pressure”

「外部壓力」

In professional writing, **external** is often more formal than **outside**.

Important distinction: **outside** vs **outer**

outside

Often describes something located externally or coming from elsewhere.

> “the outside wall”

outer

More specifically describes the part **farther from the centre / on the exterior layer**.

> “the outer layer of the skin”

「皮膚的外層」

They overlap, but:

* **outside help** ✓

* **outer help** ✗

Important distinction: **outside** vs **exterior**

outside

Broad everyday word.

> “the outside of the building”

exterior

More formal noun/adjective referring specifically to the external surface or appearance.

> “the building’s exterior”

「建築物的外部／外觀」

exterior cannot replace **outside** in many figurative uses:

> “outside my expertise” ✓

> “exterior my expertise” ❌

Important distinction: **outside** vs **outsider**

outside

= location, position, or status beyond a boundary

outsider

= a **person** who is outside a particular social/group boundary

> “She came from outside the organization.”

「她來自機構以外。」

> “She was an outsider in the organization.”

「她在機構內被視為一個外來者／局外人。」

Important grammar note: **outside** vs **outside of**

Both occur:

> “outside the building”

> “outside of the building”

In most physical-location contexts, **outside + noun** is simpler and more concise:

> “Wait outside the station.”

outside of is particularly common in American English and is also used figuratively:

> “Outside of work, I rarely use email.”

Here it means:

除了／在……以外

In more formal writing, **outside** or **apart from / except for** may sometimes be clearer depending on meaning.

Family-extension note

Following our updated Golden Manual, these practical extensions are worth flagging:

- * **outside world** = 外界／外部世界
- * **outside help** = 外來協助
- * **outside influence** = 外部影響
- * **outside consultant** = 外聘顧問
- * **outside interests** = 本職以外的興趣
- * **outside employment** = 本職工作以外的受僱工作
- * **outside chance** = 渺茫但仍存在的可能性
- * **outside estimate** = 最大合理估算
- * **outsider** = 外人／局外人
- * **outsider — competition** = 不被看好的冷門參賽者

The broad conceptual key is:

> **outside = beyond a physical, social, organizational, conceptual, or expected boundary**

That one core idea explains many of its uses.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
outside + place	位於某個有明確界線的地方之外, 而不是其內部
outside — outdoors	位於建築物或室內空間之外的戶外地方
outside + noun — external part	位於物件、建築物或範圍外側的
the outside	某物相對於內部而言的外層、外側或外部部分
outside world	某人自身、私人空間或封閉環境以外的外界現實
outside a range/scope	超出某項規則、界限、專業或既定範圍
outside consultant/help	並非來自某機構或群體內部, 而是來自外部的
outside employment/interests	不屬於某人主要職務或主要活動範圍內的
outside pressure/influence	從某個人、機構或系統以外而來的影響或干預
outside chance	成功可能性很低, 但並非完全不可能的機會
outside estimate	在合理範圍內作出的最大／最高估算
outsider — group	不屬於某個特定群體、圈子或社群的人
outsider — competition	在競爭中被認為勝算較低、不屬於熱門的一方

For your original sentence

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the **outside world**.”

The exact meaning is:

outside world = 自己當下的私人空間和內在體驗之外, 周圍真實存在的人、活動、聲音和環境

So the metaphor means:

戴上耳機後, 周圍交通、人聲、辦公室聲音等整個「外界」彷彿都被按下了靜音鍵。